

Aromatic Herbs that Open the Orifice

- These herbs act to dispel pathogenic blockages, opening the sensory orifices and awakening the spirit.
- The Heart governs the spirit. When pathogenic influences envelop and veil the clarity of the sensory orifices, the spirit becomes locked up, and the patient becomes delirious or loses consciousness in severe cases.

- Closed disorders (Bi Zheng, excess): clenched jaws, closed mouth, tight fists, delirium, irritability, convulsion, heavy breathing, and forceful pulse.
- Cold Bi: greenish facial complexion, a cold body, pale face, and slow pulse.
- Hot Bi: fever, red face, yellow tongue coat, and rapid pulse.
- Unconsciousness due to deficiency or Tuo Zheng should not be treated with the herbs that open the orifices.

Pattern	Nature	Key Symptoms	Pulse	Treatment
Closed Disorder (Bi Zheng)	Excess	Clenched jaw, convulsions, irritability, closed mouth, agitation	Forceful	Open the orifices , clear heat or warm cold
Cold Bi Zheng	Cold Excess	Pale face, cold body, slow movement	Slow	Warm orifices, transform cold phlegm
Hot Bi Zheng	Heat Excess	Fever, red face, yellow coat, delirium	Rapid, forceful	Clear heat, resolve phlegm, open orifices
Tuo Zheng (Collapse)	Deficiency	Faint breathing, cold sweat, weak pulse	Minute, weak	Tonify Yang , rescue Qi- <i>never open orifices</i>

Be sure to obtain the correct differential diagnoses, then combine them with other herbs to achieve the optimal effect.

These herbs are naturally acrid and aromatic. They consume qi and are used only in acute situations. While they restore consciousness and relieve symptoms, they do not address the underlying conditions that cause them. They are not used frequently or extensively, and are primarily used in powder or pill form.

Shè Xiāng 麝香

- *Moschus*
- English: musk, navel gland secretions of the musk deer
- Properties: acrid, warm
- Channels: Heart, Liver, Spleen

Actions and indications

Actions: Vigorously opens the orifices, revives the spirit, and unblocks Bi Zheng (Closed Disorder)

Indications: impaired consciousness caused by heat and phlegm, stroke, and convulsion. These include heat entering the Pericardium due to a warm-febrile disease.

- She Xiang is acrid and fragrantly aromatic in nature, that is, it travels through and pierces; it is one of the strongest substances in reviving the shen (spirit).
- As “Yao Yao” it is the key, indispensable ingredient when treating diseases accompanied by impaired consciousness.
- Although it is warm, it treats both hot and cold types of Bi Zheng (closed disorder) when combined with other appropriate herbs.
- Impaired consciousness caused by heat and phlegm, stroke, convulsions, and /or heat stroke: Bing Pian, Niu Huang, Zhu Sha (An Gong Niu Huang Wang)
- Infantile convulsions: Niu Huang, Ling Yang Jiao, Tian Nan Xing, Zhu Sha
- Impaired consciousness due to cold and phlegm: Su He Xiang, Tan Xiang (Su He Xiang Wan)

Actions: Invigorates the blood, dissipates clumps/clots and reduces swelling, and alleviates pain.

Indications: carbuncles, sores, hot swellings, amenorrhea, and immobile palpable masses.

- She Xiang is usually applied topically when there is not yet an open lesion on the skin. This substance is aromatic and penetrating, and is most suitable for dispersing stagnation at the blood level.
- Carbuncles, sores, and hot swellings: She Xiang, Ru Xiang, Mo Yao
- Immobile palpable masses: Xhi Shao, San Leng, E Zhu
- Amenorrhea: Dan Shen, Chi Shao, Hong Hua

Actions: Relieves Pain

Indications: Chest pain (Dan Shen, Tao Ren, Xie Bai), traumatic injuries with blood stagnation (She Xiang, Ru Xiang, Yan Hu Suo (Qi Li San)

Actions: Induces labor in a stillbirth

Indication: stillbirth. With its strong penetrating properties, She Xiang expels a dead fetus or a placenta that fails to descend.

Main Actions:

- Vigorously opens the orifices, revives the spirit, and unblocks Bi Zheng (Closed Disorder)
- Invigorates blood, dissipates clumps/clots, reduces swelling, and relieves pain
- Induces labor if there is a stillbirth

Dosages:

60 to 100 mg as powder or pills. The maximum dosage of Shen Xiang is 1.0 gram.

Note: It should not be decocted due to its strong aromatic properties.

It is also given sublingually for the treatment of angina, with effects comparable to nitroglycerin.

Cautions/contraindications:

Use of She Xiang is contraindicated in pregnancy.

It has been proposed, though not confirmed, that topical treatment may cause miscarriage, as internal use is known to do.

Review questions

- Properties of She Xiang
- Actions and indications
- Review the possible herbal combination for treating warm- febrile disease with impaired consciousness.
- It is an effective herb for pain
- Cautions with She Xiang

Bīng Piàn 冰片
“ice slice”

- *Borneolum Syntheticum*
- English: borneol
- Properties: acrid, bitter, cool
- Channels: Heart, Spleen, Lung

Actions and indications

Actions: Opens orifices, revives the Shen (spirit)

Indications: convulsions due to heat or cold. (Emergency cases)

- Heat: Bing Pian, Niu Huang, She Xiang (An Gong Niu Huang Wan)
- Cold: Su He Xiang, Bing Pian, She Xiang

Actions: Clears heat, relieves pain, and stops itching

Indications: toxic heat affecting the eyes, throat, and skin.

Actions: Opens orifices, vaporizes turbid phlegm, and quiets the shen (spirit)

Indications: forgetfulness, a dulled sensorium, deafness, dizziness, as well as seizures, epilepsy or manic behavior.

- Clears heat, relieves pain, and stops itching
- Bing Pian is one of the best herbs for topical use to reduce swelling, relieve itching, clear heat, eliminate toxins, relieve pain, prevent decay, and help to regenerate flesh.
- It can be used individually for treating eye diseases.
- Sore throat, canker sore, and toothache: Peng Sha, Zhu Sha, Xuan Ming Feng (Bing Peng San)

- Ulceration: Ru Siang, Qing Fen, Peng sha, Long Gu

Main Actions:

- Opens the orifice, revives the shen.
- Clears heat, relieves pain and stops itching

Dosage: 0.03 – 0.1 grams in pill or powder form.

Bing Pian is not used in decoctions

Cautions: Bing Pian is contraindicated in pregnancy.

Review questions

- Properties of Bing Pian
- Actions and indications of Bing Pian
- Compare She Xiang and Bing Pian.
- Review the herbs can be topical use for treating skin, eyes and gums disorder.
- The dosage of Bing Pian
- How does Bing Pian being used in medicine?

Shí Chāng Pú 石菖蒲

- Rhizoma Acori
- English: acorus, grass-leaf sweet-flag rhizome
- Properties: acrid, warm
- Channels: Heart, Stomach

Actions and Indications

Actions: Opens orifices, vaporizes turbid phlegm, and quiets the shen (spirit)

Indications: forgetfulness, a dulled sensorium, deafness, dizziness, as well as seizures, epilepsy, or manic behavior.

- Shi Chang Pi is one of the best and essential herbs for opening sensory orifices, thereby treating coma, impaired mental function when these are associated with turbid-phlegm veiling the consciousness, preventing the clear yang from ascending.
- Its warming action is relatively mild, and its actions are due to the fragrant aroma.
- Forgetfulness, insomnia, or palpitations: Ren Shen, Fu Shen, Long Yan Rou
- Tinnitus or deafness: Ci Shi, Nu Zhen Zi
- High fever with coma or unconsciousness caused by hot phlegm: Yu Jin, Yuan Zhi, Huang Lian, Dan Nan Xing
- Manic behavior with constipation: Mang Xiao, Hou Po, Zhi Shi

Actions: Transforms turbid dampness and harmonizes the Middle Jiao

Indications: dampness accumulation in the middle Jiao, leading to chest and abdominal fullness, distention, and pain, poor appetite: Huo Xiang, Cang Zhu, Chen Pi

Main Actions:

Opens orifices, vaporizes turbid phlegm, calms the shen
Transforms turbid dampness and harmonizes the Middle Jiao

Dosage: 5 – 10 grams in decoction, 10 – 20 grams for the fresh herb. It can be applied topically for skin disorders or trauma injuries.

Review questions:

- Actions and indications.
- Herbs for phlegm veil the Shen
- Herbs calm the Shen
- Herbs for diminished hearing or deafness

Sū Hé Xiāng 苏合香
“revive and join fragrance” *styrax*

- *Styrax* or *Styrax tonkinensis*
- English: styrax, resin of rose maloes, benzoin
- Properties: acrid, warm
- Channels: Heart, Spleen

Actions and indications

Actions: Opens orifices and disperses turbidity.

Indications: closed disorder, phlegm collapse and epidemic toxin disease.

Actions: Relieves Pain

Indications: abdominal pain, chest pain.

- Because it opens orifices, dispels turbidity, it indirectly alleviates pain. In recent years, this herb has been commonly used in treating coronary heart disease along with Ding Xiang, She Xiang, and An Xi Xiang.
- Su He Xiang is acrid, warm, and aromatic in nature. It is best at warming channels, opening orifices, and dispersing turbidity. It is best suited for wind-stroke or phlegm collapse in cold-closure patterns and should not be used for hot-closure patterns.
- Su He Xiang has similar actions in opening the orifices and dispersing turbidity, but Su He Xiang is not as strong as She Xiang.

Main Actions:

- Opens orifices and dispenses turbidity
- Relieves pain (chest and abdomen)

Dosage: 0.3-1.0 grams in pill form. Su He Xiang is not suitable for decoction.

Cautions:

Su He Xiang is contraindicated in Bi Zheng (closed disorder) caused by heat or deficiency

Review questions

- Property of Su He Xiang
- Actions and indications
- Use for treating what type of closed disorder?
- Review the herbs for treating chest pain.